

LCD Reference Article

Billing and Coding Article

Billing and Coding: Application of Bioengineered Skin Substitutes to Lower Extremity Chronic Non-Healing Wounds

A54117

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Contractor Information

Contractor Name	Contract Type	Contract Number	Jurisdiction	States
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	04111 - MAC A	J - H	Colorado
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	04112 - MAC B	J - H	Colorado
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	04211 - MAC A	J - H	New Mexico
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	04212 - MAC B	J - H	New Mexico
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	04311 - MAC A	J - H	Oklahoma
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	04312 - MAC B	J - H	Oklahoma

Contractor Name	Contract Type	Contract Number	Jurisdiction	States
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	04411 - MAC A	J - H	Texas
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	04412 - MAC B	J - H	Texas
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	04911 - MAC A	J - H	Colorado New Mexico Oklahoma Texas
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	07101 - MAC A	J - H	Arkansas
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	07102 - MAC B	J - H	Arkansas
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	07201 - MAC A	J - H	Louisiana
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	07202 - MAC B	J - H	Louisiana
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	07301 - MAC A	J - H	Mississippi
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	07302 - MAC B	J - H	Mississippi
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	12101 - MAC A	J - L	Delaware

Contractor Name	Contract Type	Contract Number	Jurisdiction	States
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	12102 - MAC B	J - L	Delaware
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	12201 - MAC A	J - L	District of Columbia
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	12202 - MAC B	J - L	District of Columbia
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	12301 - MAC A	J - L	Maryland
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	12302 - MAC B	J - L	Maryland
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	12401 - MAC A	J - L	New Jersey
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	12402 - MAC B	J - L	New Jersey
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	12501 - MAC A	J - L	Pennsylvania
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	12502 - MAC B	J - L	Pennsylvania

Contractor Name	Contract Type	Contract Number	Jurisdiction	States
Novitas Solutions, Inc.	A and B MAC	12901 - MAC A	J - L	Delaware District of Columbia Maryland New Jersey Pennsylvania

Article Information

General Information

Article ID

A54117

Article Title

Billing and Coding: Application of Bioengineered Skin Substitutes to Lower Extremity Chronic Non-Healing Wounds

Article Type

Billing and Coding

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10/01/2015

Revision Effective Date

01/01/2026

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N/A

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CMS National Coverage Policy

Social Security Act (Title XVIII) Standard References:

- Title XVIII of the Social Security Act, Section 1833(e) states that no payment shall be made to any provider of services or other person under this part unless there has been furnished such information as may be necessary in order to determine the amounts due such provider or other person under this part for the period with respect to which the amounts are being paid or for any prior period.

Article Guidance

Article Text

This Billing and Coding Article provides billing and coding guidance for Local Coverage Determination (LCD) L35041, Application of Bioengineered Skin Substitutes to Lower Extremity Chronic Non-Healing Wounds. Please refer to the LCD for reasonable and necessary requirements.

The addition of Skin Substitutes, Cellular or Tissue Based Products (CTPs) to certain wounds may afford a healing advantage over dressings and conservative treatments when these options appear insufficient to affect complete healing.

The individual products will continue to be identified with a Level II Healthcare Common Procedure Coding System (HCPCS) supply code from the section of the manual entitled "Skin Substitutes".

The Current Procedural Terminology (CPT) application CPT codes 15271-15278 intended for

the use of skin substitutes is entitled “Skin Substitute Grafts”. The skin replacement surgery Skin Substitute Grafts application guidelines in the current CPT codebook provide an overview of the types of procedures performed, measurement of the wound surface area, and reporting of skin closure, biological dressing, and supply of the skin substitute graft material.

These procedures are not to be reported for application of non-graft wound dressings or for a biologic implant for soft tissue reinforcement.

Coding Guidance:

Notice: It is not appropriate to bill Medicare for services that are not covered (as described by the entire LCD) as if they are covered. When billing for non-covered services, use the appropriate modifier.

Per the Current Procedural Terminology (CPT) definition, skin substitute grafts include non-autologous skin (dermal or epidermal, cellular and acellular) grafts (e.g., homograft, allograft), non-human skin substitute grafts (i.e., xenograft), and biological products that form a sheet scaffolding for skin growth. Skin substitute graft codes are not to be reported for application of non-graft wound dressings (e.g., gel, powder, ointment, foam, liquid) or injected skin substitutes.

Non-graft wound dressings or injected skin substitute codes are not used with skin replacement surgery application codes and are considered incorrect coding. Such products are bundled into other standard management procedures if medically necessary and not separately payable.

Claims reporting skin substitute grafts must contain the presence of an appropriate application CPT code.

If the service for the application code is denied, the service for the skin substitute will also be denied.

Effective 01/01/2017, per CR 9603, when billing for Part B drugs and biologicals (except those provided under Competitive Acquisition Program [CAP] for Part B drugs and biologicals), the use of the JW modifier to identify unused drugs or biologicals from single use vials or single use packages that are appropriately discarded is required. The discarded amount shall be billed on a separate claim line using the JW modifier. Providers are required to document the discarded drug or biological in the patient’s medical record.

Novitas expects that where multiple sizes of a specific product are available, the size that

best fits the wound with the least amount of wastage will be utilized.

When a portion of a drug/biological is discarded, the medical record must clearly document the amount administered and the amount wasted. The documentation must include the date, time, amount of medication wasted, and the reason for the wastage.

In situations where a portion of a **single use package** must be discarded, payment will be made for the portion discarded along with the amount applied up to the amount of the product on the package label. Medical record documentation must clearly indicate the information noted above.

Note: The unused portion must actually be discarded and may not be used for another patient.

Documentation Requirements

1. All documentation must be maintained in the patient's medical record and made available to the contractor upon request.
2. Every page of the record must be legible and include appropriate patient identification information (e.g., complete name, dates of service[s]). The documentation must include the legible signature of the physician or non-physician practitioner responsible for and providing the care to the patient.
3. The submitted medical record must support the use of the selected ICD-10-CM code(s). The submitted CPT/HCPCS code must describe the service performed.

Coding Information

CPT/HCPCS Codes

Group 1 (14 Codes)

Group 1 Paragraph

Note: Providers are reminded to refer to the long descriptors of the CPT codes in their CPT book.

The following CPT/HCPCS codes outlined in this Billing and Coding Article will not have diagnosis code limitations applied at this time.

Group 1 Codes

Code	Description
15002	Wound prep trk/arm/leg
15003	Wound prep addl 100 cm
15004	Wound prep f/n/hf/g
15005	Wnd prep f/n/hf/g addl cm
15040	Harvest cultured skin graft
15050	Pinch graft up to 2 cm diam
15271	Skin sub graft trnk/arm/leg
15272	Skin sub graft t/a/l add-on
15273	Skin sub grft t/arm/lg child
15274	Skn sub grft t/a/l child add
15275	Skin sub graft face/nk/hf/g
15276	Skin sub graft f/n/hf/g addl
15277	Skn sub grft f/n/hf/g child
15278	Skn sub grft f/n/hf/g ch add

CPT/HCPCS Modifiers

N/A

ICD-10-CM Codes that Support Medical Necessity

Group 1 (1 Code)

Group 1 Paragraph

It is the provider’s responsibility to select codes carried out to the highest level of specificity and selected from the ICD-10-CM code book appropriate to the year in which the service is rendered for the claim(s) submitted.

Group 1 Codes

Code	Description
XX000	Not Applicable

ICD-10-CM Codes that DO NOT Support Medical Necessity

Group 1 (1 Code)

Group 1 Paragraph

N/A

Group 1 Codes

Code	Description
XX000	Not Applicable

ICD-10-PCS Codes

N/A

Additional ICD-10 Information

N/A

Bill Type Codes

Contractors may specify Bill Types to help providers identify those Bill Types typically used to report this service. Absence of a Bill Type does not guarantee that the article does not apply to that Bill Type. Complete absence of all Bill Types indicates that coverage is not influenced by Bill Type and the article should be assumed to apply equally to all claims.

Code	Description
999x	Not Applicable

Revenue Codes

Contractors may specify Revenue Codes to help providers identify those Revenue Codes typically used to report this service. In most instances Revenue Codes are purely advisory. Unless specified in the article, services reported under other Revenue Codes are equally subject to this coverage determination. Complete absence of all Revenue Codes indicates that coverage is not influenced by Revenue Code and the article should be assumed to apply equally to all Revenue Codes.

Code	Description
99999	Not Applicable

Other Coding Information

N/A

Revision History Information

Revision History Date	Revision History Number	Revision History Explanation
01/01/2026	R22	Article revised and published on 01/29/2026 effective for dates of service on and after 01/01/2026 to reflect the January CPT/HCPCS Code Update. The following codes have been deleted and therefore removed from the article: C5271, C5272, C5273, C5274, C5275, C5276, C5277, and C5278.
08/13/2020	R21	Article revised and published on 08/13/2020. Based on review of this billing and coding article, the “Coding Guidance” section was updated to include proper coding information in regards to skin replacement surgery application codes and non-graft wound dressings (e.g., gel, powder, ointment, foam, liquid) or injected skin substitutes.
07/01/2020	R20	Article revised and published on 06/25/2020 effective for dates of service on and after 07/01/2020 to remove the parenthetical note related to examples of procedures not to be reported for application of non-graft wound dressings. Group 2 paragraph and codes have been deleted as Q codes representing skin substitutes, are covered when administered and consistent with the related LCD and billed with application codes. A note was added to the text to indicate HCPCS codes Q4177 and Q4206 are exceptions and do not require an application code. HCPCS codes Q4177 and Q4206 are retroactively covered for all dates of service when not billed with application codes 15271-15278.

Revision History Date	Revision History Number	Revision History Explanation
04/30/2020	R19	Article revised and published on 04/30/2020 effective for dates of service on and after 01/01/2020. The following CPT/HCPCS code has been added to group 2: Q4170.
03/12/2020	R18	Article revised and published on 03/12/2020 effective for dates of service on and after 10/01/2019. The following HCPCS code has been added to group 2: Q4226. Standard language and format changes have been made throughout the article.
02/13/2020	R17	Article revised and published in response to provider inquiries. Healthcare Common Procedure Coding System (HCPCS) code Q4197 and Q4184 were added to the article on 02/13/2020 effective for dates of services on and after 10/21/2019.
01/01/2020	R16	Article revised and published on 01/16/2020 effective for dates of service on and after 01/01/2020 to reflect the annual CPT/HCPCS code updates. The following CPT/HCPCS code(s) have been added to the CPT/HCPCS code Group 2 in the article: Q4208, Q4209, Q4210, Q4211, Q4214, Q4216, Q4217, Q4218, Q4219, Q4220, Q4221 and Q4222. For the following CPT/HCPCS code(s) either the short description and/or the long description has been changed. Depending on which description is used in this article, there may not be any change in how the code displays in the document: Q4122 and Q4165.
10/01/2019	R15	Article revised and published on 10/31/2019 in response to the October 2019 Quarterly Healthcare Common Procedure Coding System (HCPCS) Drug/Biological Code

Revision History Date	Revision History Number	Revision History Explanation
		Changes. The following HCPCS have undergone a code descriptor change: Q4165 and Q4122.
09/26/2019	R14	Article revised and published on 09/26/2019. In addition to the changes made in Revision History Number 13 below, due to system changes, the order of the Coding Section has been revised and new sections for CPT/HCPCS Modifiers and Other Coding Information have been made.
09/26/2019	R13	Article revised and published on 09/26/2019 effective for dates of service on and after 02/04/2019 to add codes Q4183, Q4187, Q4188 and Q4203 to Group 2 CPT/HCPCS codes.
03/21/2019	R12	Article revised and published on 03/21/2019 All codes from L35041, Application of Bioengineered Skin Substitutes to Lower Extremity Chronic Non-Healing Wounds, have been placed in this article per CMS Change Request 10901. Billing instruction for HCPCS code Q4172 has been removed due to code deleted with 2019 HCPCS Update. Article title has been changed to clarify that the Article is providing billing and coding information.
01/01/2019	R11	Article revised and published on 02/14/2019 effective for dates of service on and after 01/01/2019 to reflect the annual CPT/HCPCS code updates. The following CPT/HCPCS code(s) have been deleted and therefore removed from the Article: Q4131 and Q4172. The following CPT/HCPCS code(s) have been added to Group 2 Codes: Q4186, Q4190, Q4195 and Q4196. For the

Revision History Date	Revision History Number	Revision History Explanation
		following CPT/HCPCS code(s) either the short description and/or the long description was changed. Depending on which description is used in this Article, there may not be any change in how the code displays in the document: Q4133 and Q4137.
09/17/2018	R10	Article revised and published on 11/08/2018 effective for dates of service on and after 09/17/2018 to add the following HCPCS code to CPT/HCPCS Code Group 2: Q4180.
07/26/2018	R9	Article revised and published on 07/26/2018 to add HCPCS code Q4178 to CPT/HCPCS Code Group 2 effective for dates of service on and after 04/09/2018.
04/12/2018	R8	Article revised and published on 04/12/2018 to revise statement that an appropriate application CPT code is necessary when billing a skin substitute Q code.
01/01/2018	R7	Article revised and published on 01/25/2018 effective for dates of service on and after 01/01/2018 to reflect the annual CPT/HCPCS code updates. For the following CPT/HCPCS codes either the short description and/or the long description was changed: Q4132, Q4133, Q4148, Q4156, Q4158, Q4163. Depending on which description is used in this article there may not be any change in how the codes display in the document.
05/05/2017	R6	Article revised and published 07/13/2017 effective for dates of service on and after 05/05/2017 to add the following CPT/HCPCS

Revision History Date	Revision History Number	Revision History Explanation
		code to Group 2: Q4169. Revision history from 05/11/2017 should reflect that the article (not LCD) was revised.
01/01/2017	R5	LCD revised and published on 05/11/2017 effective for dates of service on and after 01/01/2017 to add the following CPT/HCPCS codes to Group 2: Q4173 and Q4175.
01/01/2017	R4	Article revised and published on 01/12/2017 effective for dates of service on and after 01/01/2017 to reflect the annual CPT/HCPCS code updates. The following CPT/HCPCS codes: C9349, Q4119, Q4120, and Q4129 have been deleted and therefore removed from group 2 of the Article. The following CPT/HCPCS codes: Q4166 and Q4172 have been added to group 2 of the Article. References to HCPCS code C9349 in the Coding Guidance section have been revised to HCPCS code Q4172. For the following CPT/HCPCS codes either the short description and/or the long description was changed. Depending on which description is used in this LCD, there may not be any change in how the code displays in the document: Q4105 and Q4131. Coding Guidance added regarding use of JW modifier.
04/18/2016	R3	Article revised and published on 07/14/2016 effective for dates of service on and after 04/18/2016 to add HCPCS code Q4128 to the Group 2 codes.
01/01/2016	R2	Article revised and published on 01/28/2016 effective for dates of service on and after 01/01/2016 to reflect the annual CPT/HCPCS code updates. The following CPT/HCPCS codes have been added to Group 2: Q4161, Q4163, Q4164, and Q4165. For the following CPT/HCPCS code, either the short description and/or the

Revision History Date	Revision History Number	Revision History Explanation
		long description was changed. Depending on which description is used in this LCD, there may not be any change in how the code displays in the document: Q4153.
10/01/2015	R1	Article revised and published on 08/13/2015 to add HCPCS codes Q4146 and Q4147. The HCPCS code descriptor for C9349 has changed in response to the 2015 HCPCS Quarter 3 update.

Associated Documents

Related Local Coverage Documents

LCDs

[L35041 - Application of Bioengineered Skin Substitutes to Lower Extremity Chronic Non-Healing Wounds](#) 

Related National Coverage Documents

NCDs

[270.3 - Blood-Derived Products for Chronic Non-Healing Wounds](#) 

Statutory Requirements URLs

N/A

Rules and Regulations URLs

N/A

CMS Manual Explanations URLs

N/A

Other URLs

N/A

Public Versions

Updated On	Effective Dates	Status	
01/23/2026	01/01/2026 - N/A	Currently in Effect	You are here
08/06/2020	08/13/2020 - 12/31/2025	Superseded	View

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Keywords

N/A